

What else to watch: *Look Back in Anger* (1959) ■ *À bout de souffle* (1960; pp.166–67) ■ *The Loneliness of the Long Distance Runner* (1962) ■ *Billy Liar* (1963) ■ *This Sporting Life* (1963) ■ *Alfie* (1966) ■ *Kes* (1969, p.336) ■ *Naked* (1993, p.340–41)



The poster style was influenced by that of the French movie *À bout de souffle*, made in the same year.

movements aimed for a more authentic approach to filmmaking by venturing out of the studio and into real locations.

British New Wave filmmakers, however, were less concerned with innovative cinematography than their French peers. The realism they sought was in their subject matter: the personal lives of the working class. The first of these “kitchen sink” dramas on film was *Look Back in Anger* (1959), adapted from John Osborne’s play. It spawned the so-called Angry Young Man movie genre of the 1960s, featuring working-class heroes.

Yet while *Look Back in Anger* is relatively theatrical, *Saturday Night and Sunday Morning* is matter-of-fact, almost documentary, in its depiction of the troubled lives of its characters. It pulls no punches

in its inclusion of adultery, abortion, drunkenness, and violence as everyday realities. Fifty years on, such dramas are the staple of British television soaps, but in 1960 they were new. Arthur, brilliantly

portrayed by Albert Finney, is determined not to be diminished by the limitations of life as a lathe operator at a bicycle factory in Nottingham. He rebels against the drudgery of his class.

Bucking expectations

Despite his declaration “That’s what all these loony laws are for, to be broken by blokes like us,” Arthur is neither a political rebel nor a criminal. He simply bucks expectations by having an affair with Brenda (Rachel Roberts), the wife of an older colleague, while two-timing her with young Doreen (Shirley Anne Field). Even this small personal rebellion is brought low by reality when Brenda becomes pregnant and is forced into an abortion, and Arthur is beaten up by Brenda’s husband and his soldier friends. Yet Arthur’s spirit is not crushed, and although harrowing, the film is ultimately uplifting. ■

“What I’m out for is a good time—all the rest is propaganda!”

Arthur Seaton / *Saturday Night and Sunday Morning*



Karel Reisz Director

Born in Ostrava, Czechoslovakia, in 1926, Karel Reisz was sent to Britain when

he was 12, just before Nazi Germany invaded his country in 1939. His parents died in Auschwitz. He served in World War II and studied chemistry at Cambridge, then became a film critic. Reisz led the Free Cinema

movement, which strived for a less class-bound, more politically aware British cinema, and began to direct his own movies in 1960.

Key movies

1960 *Saturday Night and Sunday Morning*
1964 *Night Must Fall*
1981 *The French Lieutenant’s Woman*